



WILDFIRE SMOKE from the Palisades and Eaton fires blankets much of Los Angeles County on Jan. 8.

Barbs fly amid push for troops in Chicago

Trump assails Illinois leaders fighting his efforts to deploy the National Guard.

By ANA CEBALLOS AND MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — Chicago is emerging as the latest testing ground for President Trump's domestic deployment of military force as hundreds of National Guard troops were expected to descend on the city.

The president said Wednesday that Illinois Gov. JB Pritzker and Chicago Mayor Brandon Johnson should be jailed for failing to support federal agents, and continued to paint a dark and violent picture of both Chicago and Portland, Ore., where Trump is trying to send federal troops but has so far been stonewalled by the courts.

"It's so bad," Trump said at the White House on Wednesday. "It's so crazy. It's like the movies ... where you have these bombed-out cities and these bombed-out people. It's worse than that. I don't think they can make a movie as bad."

Pritzker this week characterized Trump's depiction of Chicago as "deranged" and untrue. Federal agents are making the community "less safe," the governor said, noting that residents do not want "Donald Trump to occupy their communities" and that people of color are fearful of being profiled during immigration crackdowns.

Trump has taken issue with Democrats in Illinois and Oregon who are fighting his efforts, and has twice said this week that he is willing to use the Insurrection Act of 1807 if local leaders and the courts try to stop him. White House Deputy Chief of Staff Stephen Miller also contended this week that a court ruling blocking Trump's deployments to Portland amounted to a "legal insurrection" as well as "an insurrection against the laws and Constitution of the United States."

In a televised interview Monday, Miller was asked about his remarks and asked whether the administration would abide by court rulings that stop the deployment of troops to Illinois and Portland. Miller responded by saying the president has "plenary authority" before going silent midsentence — a moment that the host said may have been a technical issue.

"Plenary authority" is a legal term that indicates someone has limitless power.

The legality of deployments to Portland and Chicago will face scrutiny in two federal courts Thursday.

The U.S. 9th Circuit [See Chicago, A5]

AI VIDEO ADS ARE POSTURING AS NEWS

Artificial intelligence is now part of advertisers' arsenal, and some are not holding back in making it harder to detect sales pitches

By Niles Christopher

In a short-form video post, an influencer gets worked up about a television news story from California. The images broadcast behind her appear authentic, with an anchor calling viewers to action, victims and even a CNN logo.

"California accident victims getting insane payouts," the anchor says above a banner touting "BREAKING NEWS."

But what might seem to be a social media star excited about local news is actually an advertisement to entice people to sign up for legal services. And much of it is generated by artificial intelligence.

With a slew of new AI video tools and new ways to share them launched in recent months, the line between newscast and sales pitch is starting to blur.

Personal injury lawyers have long been known for over-the-top ads. They tap into the latest methods — radio, television, 1-800 numbers, billboards, bus stop benches and infomercials — to burn their brands into consumers' consciousness.

The ads are intentionally repetitive, outrageous and catchy, so if viewers have an accident, they recall whom to call.

Now they are using AI to create a new wave of ads that are more convincing, compelling and local.

"Online ads for both goods and services are using AI-generated humans and AI replicas of influencers to promote their brand without disclosing the synthetic nature of the people represented," said Alexios Mantzarlis, the director of trust, safety and security at Cornell Tech. "This trend is not encouraging for the pursuit of truth in advertising."

It isn't just television news that is being cloned by bots. Increasingly, the screaming headlines in people's news feeds are generated by AI on behalf of advertisers.

In one online debt repayment ad, a man holds a newspaper with a headline suggesting California residents with

[See AI ads, A10]

California to ban in schools some ultraprocessed foods

New state law targets meals 'of concern,' but some items will be exempt. Here's why.

By DANIEL MILLER

It's a little after 9:30 a.m. on a recent weekday, and hair-netted workers at the Alhambra Unified School District's central production kitchen are boxing up the last of 350 handmade sushi rolls for the city's three high schools.

The spicy tuna rolls, redolent of cooked fish blended with sriracha and mayonnaise, are a popular lunch offering among students.

"It's one of our signature items that you can never take away," said Dwayne Dionne, Alhambra Unified's culinary specialist.

Alhambra Unified has sold the sushi for about 25 years. At one point, the district switched from white to brown rice — a healthier whole grain. Yet, it's the kind of meal that will be scrutinized under a new state law: the Real Food, Healthy Kids Act.

The law, which Gov. Gavin Newsom signed on Wednesday, provides a first-ever statutory definition of ultraprocessed foods in the U.S. and will ban some that are "of concern" in California schools starting in 2035.

Under the legislation,

which is expected to touch off a major overhaul of school cafeteria meals, the state's Department of Public Health will identify ultraprocessed foods "of concern" and "restricted school foods" — another prohibited category — by 2028. A year later, schools are required to begin phasing them out.

"There's this really great opportunity to help a ton of people in a pretty straightforward way," said Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino), author of the legislation. "I'm still learning about all this. ... I [was] going to the grocery store trying to do right by my kids, but had no idea that we might be

[See Meals, A7]

Arrest made in Palisades wildfire probe

29-year-old accused of starting initial blaze. LAFD actions face heightened scrutiny.

By RICHARD WINTON, HANNAH FRY, CHRISTOPHER BUCHANAN, TONY BRISCOE AND HAILEY BRANSON-POTTS

The most destructive inferno in Los Angeles history, which charred a devastating path through Pacific Palisades and Malibu in early January, was a flare-up of a fire that an Uber driver had intentionally set days earlier, federal prosecutors alleged Wednesday.

Jonathan Rinderknecht, 29, is accused of starting the initial fire on New Year's Day that rekindled to become the Palisades fire. He was arrested Wednesday in Florida and charged with destruction of property by means of fire, which carries a minimum of five years in federal prison.

Among the evidence collected from Rinderknecht's digital devices was a dystopian image he generated on ChatGPT depicting a burning city with people trying to flee, said Bill Essayli, acting U.S. attorney for the Central District of California, at a news conference Wednesday.

Rinderknecht called 911 to report the fire, then offered to help firefighters battle the blaze, according to an affidavit by an agent with the Bureau of Alcohol, Tobacco, Firearms and Explosives. Prosecutors accused Rinderknecht of lying about where he was when he made his first 911 call.

"While we cannot undo the damage and destruction that was done, we hope his arrest and the charges against him bring some measure of justice to the victims of this horrific tragedy," Essayli said.

The federal prosecution affirms a long-suspected theory among fire experts and comes after a nine-month investigation into the cause of the Palisades fire, which charred 23,400 acres and leveled more than 6,800 structures, including many homes. Twelve people died in the blaze.

[See Arrest, A6]

SUSPECT'S LIFE IN L.A. BEFORE THE BLAZE

By MATT HAMILTON, NATHAN SOLIS, TERRY CASTLEMAN, SALVADOR HERNANDEZ AND JULIA WICK

He's the son of Baptist missionaries who loved soccer as a child.

In the Hollywood neighborhood where he lived and worked as an Uber driver, one acquaintance described him as "a really nice guy." Yet he was embroiled in an ugly legal conflict with a neighbor in his apartment complex that included accusations of abuse and drug use.

Now, federal prosecutors accuse Jonathan Rinderknecht, 29, of intentionally sparking one of the most destructive fires in California history.

In a court filing, authorities accuse Rinderknecht of setting a fire just after midnight on Jan. 1 along a popular hiking trail in Pacific Palisades. They allege he repeatedly listened to a brooding French rap song and downloaded an AI-generated image depicting a burning city.

Rinderknecht could not be reached for comment, and authorities did not offer a motive for the alleged actions.

According to public records and posts on social media, the 29-year-old has roots in Florida, Hollywood, Pacific Palisades and the south of France, where his parents did missionary work.

As recently as this spring, records show, Rinderknecht lived and was registered to vote at a Hollywood apartment building, just north of Hollywood Boulevard, near the Roosevelt Hotel.

A few months ago, federal agents with the Bureau of Alcohol, Tobacco, Firearms and Explosives visited the complex and appeared to search his unit. The agents carried guns, a neighbor

[See Suspect, A7]



AUTHORITIES announce the arrest of Jonathan Rinderknecht, a suspect in starting the Palisades fire.

ANALYSIS

Trump declares Gaza deal

By MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — A peace plan for Gaza touted by President Trump as a historic breakthrough is facing its first hurdle this week, after Israel and Hamas agreed in principle to a list of terms that could end the war.

The 20-point American plan reflects an administration losing patience with Israel, while also leveraging its relationships with Arab partners to finally pressure Hamas into a deal that would release the Israeli hostages still in its custody two years after the Oct. 7 attack.

On Wednesday evening, Trump said both parties had agreed to the first phase of his plan, securing the hostage release in exchange for a limited Israeli troop withdrawal.

"I am very proud to announce that Israel and Hamas have both signed off on the first Phase of our Peace Plan," Trump wrote on social media. "This means that ALL of the Hostages will be released very soon, and Israel will withdraw their Troops to an agreed upon line as the first steps toward a Strong, Durable, and Everlasting Peace."

The president's push

comes amid an unexpected and growing divide within the Republican base over support for Israel — once seen as a bedrock of the alliance — and as Trump presents himself as a global peacemaker, ahead of the announcement of this year's Nobel Peace Prize on Friday.

The president is expected to travel to the region over the weekend to secure the deal.

"All Parties will be treated fairly!" Trump wrote. "BLESSED ARE THE PEACEMAKERS!"

One former senior Biden administration official who worked on the Gaza crisis

[See Gaza, A5]

Theories abound in refinery fire

Experts say the scale of El Segundo blast raises concerns and warrants investigation into its cause. CALIFORNIA, B1

LACMA receives its first Klimt

Family of Viennese art dealer is donating more than 100 works totaling more than \$60 million. ENTERTAINMENT, E1

Weather

Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 79/62. B6

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